address to the participants, the Prime Minister of Bangladesh, Sheikh Hasina, the daughter of Sheikh Mujibur Rahman, acknowledged the sacrifices made by the Indian Army in their freedom struggle and said that Bangladesh would always remain grateful.

Another low-key visit (as with Bhutan) was the one to Myanmar undertaken by me and the FS, Shri Harsh Vardhan Shringla, in late Oct 2020. In fact, ours was the last high-level delegation to Myanmar prior to their General Elections of November 2020, in which Daw Aung Sang Suu Kyi's party, the National League for Democracy, won a landslide victory leading ultimately led to the military coup of February 2021. It was the first time I met ASSK, as she had been under house arrest throughout my DA tenure in Myanmar, with even the road leading to her bungalow on the bank of the Inya Lake blocked for normal traffic. It was an honour to meet such an iconic figure but it was apparent even then that there was no love lost between her and the military. In fact, at one point during our discussions she even said, 'I wish our Army was as professional as yours,' in an obvious reference to the apolitical nature of the Indian Army.

There was another interesting incident during the visit. Just before the formal interaction, the FS came to me saying that in the seating plan, the Myanmar side had put him (FS) at the head and myself in the second seat. The FS had pointed out to his counterpart that I was the head of the Delegation but was told that this was the plan approved by ASSK. We were in a quandary as to what to do, with the FS volunteering to talk to the Myanmar side once again. I thought that it would be a waste of time especially as the meeting was about to commence. We decided that we would enter the conference room with me leading the way and I would naturally take the first seat as the head of the delegation, which would be face-saving for all.

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